

COARA ACTION PLAN - UNIVERSITY OF MILAN





The University of Milan has been committed for years in supporting open science and in underlying criteria of transparency, accessibility and reproducibility. For years, the openness of publications and data has been supported with ad hoc fundings, extensive training courses especially dedicated to early career researchers, a diamond university press, and the communication of the results achieved at the national and international level. Open science is one of the goals of the university's strategic plan, which aims to implement at least 6 of the European Commission's 8 pillars.

Consequently, openness, transparency and reproducibility are also among the goals of departments, research groups and individuals researchers, whose research results are reported publicly in reports and dashboards.

The university has also recently joined the Barcelona declaration on open research information, reaffirming its existing commitment from 2023 to the exclusive use of open data for research analysis and monitoring. Over the past 10 years, therefore, the university has worked to make a cultural change effective, working on training but also on open and transparent documentation of achievements. In this, collaboration with European alliances has been crucial.

All that considered, the time is ripe to initiate a series of short- and medium-term actions, described in this action plan, that take into consideration the state of the art in the institution and the results already achieved, the challenges posed by the national context and the constraints imposed by the Ministry of Research, which therefore represents an interlocutor whom to deal with together with all the other signatory institutions and the members of the National Chapter.

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Version 1 (prepared by Paola Galimberti)



	Scope	Actions	Timeframe
1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research Purpose: This commitment will broaden recognition of the diverse practices, activities and careers in research, considering the specific nature of research disciplines and other research endeavours.	The university also recognizes the importance of transparency and reproducibility of research processes through specific actions designed to reward dedicated efforts such as data curation, preregistration or preprint publication. The university also recognizes the commitment and involvement of professors and researchers in diamond open access initiatives such as editing journals or writing textbooks for students	Introduction of a Third Mission and an OS dimension in the salary increment procedures (e.g. it is asked to include relevant achievements, including not only publications, but also datasets, software, services, and so on)	From 2025
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators Purpose: This commitment will enable the move towards research assessment criteria that focus primarily on quality, while	Training on peer review (unbiased, equitable and transparent). The University recognizes the importance of the peer review in the process of quality assurance of research and considers peer review training for younger researchers fundamental for a cultural change.	Ad hoc courses will be provided for early career researchers to raise awareness toward fair and equitable (open) peer review	2024 a pilot training From 2025 a regular training 2025



recognising that responsible use of quantitative indicators can support assessment where meaningful and relevant, which is context dependent.	Awareness in the use of automated tools (AI) Establishing an environment that can critically address the challenges of scholarly communication	Publication of a regulation on the acceptable use of AI in research activities The university is also committed, as it has been in the past, to organizing events on qualitative assessment and its implementation in different disciplinary areas	Starting from 2024
3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index Purpose: This commitment will reduce the dominance of a narrow set of quantitative journal and publication-based metrics	Within a rather complex frame with obligations stemming from the ministry finding a way in which the purpose of the evaluation is not to avoid recourse, but to select the most suitable cvs for the specific position	Guidelines for the internal commissions (respectful of the ministerial rules) will be issued and their implementation will be monitored	From 2025
4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment Purpose: This commitment will help avoid that metrics used by international rankings, which are inappropriate for assessing researchers, trickle down to research and researcher assessment. It will help the research community and research	The University is committed to put no emphasis on ranking and to explain their nature and scope to the community. With respect to the use of quantitative indicators, governing bodies have approved a document on the responsible use of metrics	Progressive and further reduction in participation in rankings, along with better and more complete communication of what the university does and its strengths	From 2025



organisations regain the autonomy to shape assessment practices, rather than having to abide by criteria and methodologies set by external commercial companies. This could include retaining control over ranking methodologies and data			
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to Purpose: This commitment will ensure that organisations allocate the necessary resources, whether in the form of budget or staff capacity, to improve research assessment practices within their agreed timeframe.	The University is committed to demonstrate the validity of open interoperable infrastructures for research evaluation at the level of areas, groups, departments.	Among the first signatories of the Barcelona declaration, the university is engaged and will engage in the implementation of multidimensional public dashboards. The first one will describe the university's collaborations and their intensity. Collaboration with the Computer science department and other universities will be crucial	ongoing
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes 6.1 CRITERIA FOR UNITS AND INSTITUTIONS With the direct involvement of research organisations and researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria for assessing research units and research performing organisations, while promoting interoperability	Creating a coherent framework at the regional and national levels while also taking into account the assessment exercises taking place in different ministries. In this, the collaboration with other national institutions signatories of COARA is crucial also taking into account the roadmap of ANVUR	Initiating advocacy efforts toward the region and ministries (Health and Research Ministries) together with other COARA signatories	Starting from 2025



Purpose: This commitment will ensure that national / regional / organisational authorities and evaluation agencies review and, where needed, develop criteria for the assessment of research performing units and organisations, in accordance with the Principles. It will foster the responsible use of metrics in assessing research performing units and organisations, and help to prevent contradictions or incompatibilities between the assessment of research, researchers and research performing organisations. It will also safeguard the interoperability of adapted or newly developed assessment processes.	For more than two decades, the university has been working in synergy with the League of European research intensive universities LERU, on various issues including research evaluation both at the institution and individual researcher level by acquiring and processing, through LERU , all the European Commission's guidance		
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes 6.2 CRITERIA FOR PROJECTS AND RESEARCHERS With the direct involvement of researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria, tools and processes for the assessment of research projects, research teams and	An analysis of existing processes and criteria is essential to understand what the scope for intervention may be, taking into account the constraints and specificities of the disciplines	Analysis and review of indicators used for different processes, starting with internal ones: distribution of university funds, salary increases	From 2025



researchers that are adapted to their context of application Purpose: This commitment will enable recognition of the diverse research activities and practices through the revision and development of assessment criteria, tools, and processes. It will ensure that organisations review their processes and make tangible changes by developing existing or new assessment approaches, individually or in collaboration with others, in accordance with the Principles			
7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use Purpose: This commitment will ensure that organisations raise awareness of the reform among all actors. It will ensure that organisations transparently communicate the criteria, tools and processes used for research assessment and train researchers and assessors in their use.	The University already offers courses on evaluation, the distorting effects of entirely quantitative evaluation with a warning, however, also to so-called predatory peer review practices and review mills.	The university plans to increase training on evaluation criteria particularly the pros and cons of quantitative and qualitative systems	From 2024



8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition Purpose: This commitment will ensure organisations exchange and make use of information for mutual learning. It will help avoid fragmentation, contribute to the coherence of assessment practices between organisations, and enable researcher mobility. It also will allow those further ahead to share approaches and lessons learned, to benefit those who have further to go on their reform journey.	Continue with the exchange of experience and information with members of the national chapter and in the different working groups	Continued participation in national chapter tasks	Ongoing
9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments Purpose: This commitment will ensure organisations update one another on the progress made. It will foster careful self-reflection and monitoring of their own adherence to the Principles and progress towards meeting the Commitments.	Communication and sharing of progress made against the goals defined in this roadmap should be done periodically to the entire community and governing bodies.	Publishing our CoARA roadmap on public platforms once finalized Monitoring the roadmap implementation	From 2024
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in	The university periodically assesses the adherence of scientific production to open	Monitoring of the different dimension of open science, publication of reports on the	ongoing



research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research Purpose: This commitment will ensure that assessment approach decisions are evidence informed. It will help organisations reflect on their own processes, gain understanding about whether assessment practices achieve the desired goals and engage in evolutive assessment based on new evidence as it becomes available. It will also help to ensure control and ownership of research assessment data by the research community.	science criteria, both through a dashboard that measures the percentage of open access papers out of the total, and through multidimensional reports on the 8 pillars submitted annually to the governing bodies and published in Zenodo. The university is committed to continue this monitoring activity as a basis for the assessment of the implemented policies.	different aspects (also critical) of open science	
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